

# HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN ALBANIA

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*Complete Community Opposition How-To*

## INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

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Community action decides project outcomes in Albania, and one wild river proved it against a whole programme of dams. The **Vjosa** — one of the last free-flowing rivers in Europe, running more than four hundred kilometres from the mountains of Greece to the Adriatic, home to over a thousand species — was slated for a cascade of hydropower dams, the **Kalivaç** and the **Poçëm** among them, part of a Balkan dam boom of thousands of planned projects. The government backed them; a foreign consortium held the concession. But Albanians would not lose their river. Riverside mayors and residents, together with the local group **EcoAlbania** and the international **Save the Blue Heart of Europe** campaign led by **Riverwatch** and **EuroNatur**, backed by scientists, by the outdoor company **Patagonia**, and by **IUCN**, did not merely fight the dams one by one. The breadth of that alliance mattered enormously, and is worth naming: an international campaign that had spent years fighting the Balkan dam boom brought experience and reach; a global conservation body brought the standards by which a place is judged worthy of protection; a values-driven company brought resources and a worldwide platform; and Albanian scientists brought the evidence of the river's life. A single riverside village could not have summoned any of these; together they turned a local grievance into an international cause the government could not ignore. They documented the river's extraordinary life, challenged the dam permits in court and won, carried the fight to the world's media, and pressed a single, larger demand: not just stop the dams, but **protect the whole river as a national park**. Eight years on, in **March 2023**, the government declared the Vjosa a **Wild River National Park** — the first in Europe. A community that had been told a river was a site for dams had turned it, instead, into a protected wild river forever. The details are worth setting down, because they are the lessons. The Vjosa and its tributaries run free for more than four hundred kilometres, from the Pindus mountains in Greece, where the river is called the Aoos, to the Adriatic, and they hold over a thousand animal species, more than a dozen of them globally threatened. The campaign did not begin as a bid for a park; it began, back in 2014, with riverside mayors and residents holding a press conference on the bank and calling on the prime minister to reject the dams and make the river a national park instead. It took a first biodiversity survey with scientists and students, an international protest, lawsuits against the dams, the termination of one dam concession, and, in 2022, a formal agreement between the government and a corporate ally, before the declaration finally came in the spring of 2023.

The Vjosa story teaches two things about winning in Albania — including its hard limits, which this guide will not hide. The first is the pattern: not a single silver bullet, but the combination of every lever — the riverside communities, the local and international NGOs, the biodiversity science, the court challenges, the world's attention, the corporate ally, and the government finally won over — pressed together until the park was declared. The second is distinctly Albanian. **The most powerful move here was to shift the whole fight from "stop this dam" to "protect the whole river"** — to set a positive, permanent goal, a **national park**, that the science justified and the government could be persuaded to embrace, rather than only reacting to one project after another. This is a genuinely powerful and slightly counter-intuitive insight, and worth grasping: a purely defensive campaign, fighting each dam as it is proposed, can win battles and still lose the river, because the proponent need only succeed once, while the community must succeed every time. A campaign that instead sets the positive goal of permanent protection changes the game — it gives the public something to be for, not just against; it gives the science a purpose; and it offers the government a prize to claim rather than only a fight to lose. The Vjosa was saved when its defenders stopped asking only that this dam be cancelled and started demanding that the whole river be protected forever. That, together with **international and corporate partnership**, **biodiversity science** as the foundation, **court challenges** to individual dam permits, and **converting the government from proponent to protector**, gives communities here a real and distinctive power.

But the same story carries honest warnings, and this guide states them plainly. The Vjosa win relied heavily on **international partners and a persuadable government** — the global campaign, Patagonia, IUCN, and, in the end, a government willing to embrace the park for its own reasons, including tourism and prestige — leverage not always available. A community without such international allies, or facing a government wholly set against protection, will find the Albanian model harder to follow, and should be honest with itself about that from the start: the reframing to a park is most powerful where the value is outstanding enough to attract international partners and where the government has some incentive, however self-interested, to be won over. Where those conditions are thin, the realistic gains are the court challenge, the delay, and the record. The win is real but its **implementation is unfinished**: protection must be extended to tributaries and the delta, boundaries and management strengthened. It **protected one river** while the wider dam boom pressed on across other Balkan rivers. And Albania's **governance is weak**, its institutions corruptible, and

**development pressure** — roads, an airport near the delta, tourism — continues even beside a protected river. This guide is written with both truths in view: the real, distinctive power of a community that reframes the fight toward permanent protection, and the reliance on partners, the unfinished implementation, and the weak governance that qualify it.

Most communities do not know HOW to make opposition effective. They discover a dam or a project already conceded, assume "the government and the investor have decided," and never document the river, never challenge the permit, never reach the international campaigns, never reframe the fight toward a park, never build the coalition. They generate private loss without a public campaign. The gap between a community that saves its river and one that watches the concrete pour is rarely courage — Albanians defended the Vjosa for years. It is method: knowing that a defensive fight against one dam can become a winning fight for a whole protected river, through the science, the courts, the world, and a government that can be turned.

**This guide shows what actually works — inside the Albanian system as it is.**

## The Strategic Framework

Effective opposition campaigns follow the same underlying pattern, whichever project they face:

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STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION (find the project, the permit, and the bigger goal)
      |
STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION         (build proof of the river's value and the harm)
      |
STEP 3: LOCAL OPPOSITION      (build the coalition, local to international)
      |
STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES      (the permits, the courts, and the protection)
      |
STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY        (make it national and international)
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These steps operate **simultaneously, not in sequence**. Documentation feeds the court case and the public argument at once; the coalition sustains the pressure; a court challenge is a headline and a headline builds the movement and the international campaign. The community that runs all five together, each reinforcing the others, is the one that wins. The Vjosa campaign did exactly this — it documented the river, challenged the dam permits, built a local-to-international coalition, carried the fight to the world, and pressed the positive demand of a national park, until the government granted it.

## The Levers That Are Distinctly Strong Here

Every country's system has its own pressure points. Albania's give communities a distinctive set:

- **Reframing to protection.** The strongest move at the Vjosa was to demand not just the stopping of dams but the **permanent protection** of the whole river as a **national park** — a positive goal the science justified and the government could embrace.
- **International and corporate partnership.** The **Save the Blue Heart** campaign, IUCN, and Patagonia brought global attention, expertise, and pressure a local group alone could not.
- **Biodiversity science.** Documenting a river's or a place's **exceptional biodiversity** builds the case for the highest protection, as the Vjosa surveys did. The science does something specific and powerful in a protection campaign: it converts a felt sense that a place is special into a documented, measurable case that the place meets recognised international criteria for a national park, which is a claim a government and a conservation body can act on. The Vjosa's biodiversity surveys — begun with scientists and students on the riverbank — were not an academic exercise but the evidentiary foundation of the whole demand for protection, and any Albanian campaign that aims at a park should build that evidence early.
- **Court challenges to permits.** Albanian **administrative courts** can annul a dam or project permit for a deficient assessment, as they did for a Vjosa dam — buying time and precedent.
- **A persuadable government.** Albania's government, seeking EU accession, tourism, and prestige, can be **turned from proponent to protector** when the pressure and the incentive align.

## What This Guide Will Not Pretend

It would be dishonest to promise these levers always deliver. The Vjosa win leaned on **international partners and a willing government** not every fight will have. **Implementation is unfinished**, and protection can be partial or weakly managed. The win **saved one river** while others were dammed. And **weak governance, corruption, and development pressure** persist. This guide takes those limits seriously, names them plainly, and shows you how to fight anyway — reframing toward permanent protection, marshalling the science, challenging the permits, reaching the international campaigns, and converting the government, as the Vjosa's defenders did.

# HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

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You cannot pull a lever you cannot see. Before you spend a single weekend, map who actually decides your project's fate, at which level, and where along that path the decision is weakest.

## The Levels of Decision

An Albanian development project runs through several tracks at once, and each is a place to intervene.

**The concession and permit.** The government grants **concessions and permits** — for a dam, a mine, a development — often to a foreign or connected consortium, based on an **environmental impact assessment**. This is the instrument of harm, and a deficient assessment is a vulnerability.

**The courts.** Albanian **administrative courts** can review and **annul** a permit for a flawed assessment or process, as they did for a Vjosa dam. A real, if slow, lever.

**The government and the protection.** The **government and the environment ministry** approve projects — but can also be persuaded to **protect** an area, declaring a **national park** or protected area, as they did for the Vjosa. This level can be either your obstacle or your prize. It is worth dwelling on this dual nature, because it is the crux of an Albanian campaign: the same government that grants the destructive concession also holds the power to declare a national park, so the strategic question is not only how to defeat the government's project but how to change what the government wants — to make it prefer the park to the dam. That is a different and more ambitious task than simply opposing a decision, and it is the task the Vjosa campaign ultimately accomplished.

**The international level. EU-accession expectations, international conventions, IUCN standards, and global campaigns** bear on Albania, and the government is sensitive to its international standing. This sensitivity is a real lever in Albania, more so than in a country indifferent to outside opinion: a government pursuing EU membership and courting international investment and tourism cares how it is seen by European institutions, global conservation bodies, and the international press, and a campaign that engages those audiences reaches the government through a channel it cannot easily ignore. The Vjosa campaign's international dimension was not decoration; it was a direct line to the government's own priorities.

**The public and civil society.** A **mobilised public, riverside communities, and civil society** are the force that carries the fight and moves the government.

## The Journey of a Project

A typical project moves from a **concession** granted on an **assessment**, through the **courts** if challenged, toward construction — with the **public, the NGOs, and the international campaigns** able to document, litigate, and press for **protection** at any point. **Every one of those stages is a door you can put your foot in.** The distinctive Albanian door is the largest: **turning the government toward protection**, declaring the whole area a park, rather than only fighting each project. The **court challenge** to a permit and the **international pressure** are others. Find out exactly where your project stands — and, crucially, whether the bigger prize of **permanent protection** is within reach, because that is often the winning frame.

## Follow the Project, the River, and the Government

Behind the project stand a proponent — a dam or development consortium, often foreign or connected — the **government that granted the concession**, and the officials who signed it. Trace who holds the concession, who profits, who granted it, and — critically in Albania — **what the project destroys of a river, a valley, or a place of exceptional natural value, whether its assessment is sound, and whether the government can be moved to protect the area instead.** Two questions unlock most Albanian fights: **What is the natural value at stake, and can it justify permanent protection?** and **Is the permit legally vulnerable, and can the government be turned toward a park?** The natural value and the government's persuadability are, together, the heart of most Albanian campaigns. The two are linked: it is precisely the documented, internationally recognised value of a place that gives the government a reason to be persuaded, because protecting something the world agrees is exceptional earns the prestige and goodwill the government seeks, while protecting an ordinary site earns it little. A campaign that establishes outstanding value is therefore not only building a conservation case but building the government's own incentive to say yes — which is why the value comes first.

## The Overseers

Finally, know the bodies that watch the deciders, because they are levers too. The **administrative courts**, which can annul a permit; the **international bodies** — IUCN, EU institutions, conservation networks — whose standards and attention the government heeds; the **NGOs and the press**, local and international; and the **public**, the ultimate overseer. The domestic institutions are weak and corruptible, so the **international level and the courts** carry unusual weight. In Albania, the **reframing toward protection and the international partnership** are the two levers most distinctive and decisive, because they can turn a defensive fight into a permanent win. Each is a separate front, and a project that destroys a place of exceptional value, rests on a flawed permit, and faces a government pressed by the world and its own courts rarely survives when the alternative of protection is on the table. You do not have to choose one front: the same well-built file — the biodiversity science, the flawed permit, the case for a park — can go to the courts, IUCN, the international campaigns, the press, and the government at once, and each front that opens strengthens the others and the case for protection. An Albanian campaign’s power comes not from any single lever but from pressing several together, with the reframing to protection and the international partnership as the two that reach furthest.

## QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Before you commit what may be a years-long effort, calibrate honestly. These figures are **directional, not guarantees** — patterns drawn from how Albanian and comparable campaigns tend to go, not a controlled study. The decisive variables are whether the place has **exceptional natural value** that can justify protection, whether the **permit is legally vulnerable**, whether **international partners and campaigns** can be enlisted, whether the **government can be turned**, and whether the fight can be **reframed from stopping a project to winning permanent protection**. Where a river or place of outstanding value meets a flawed permit, strong international backing, and a persuadable government, Albania's levers are real, as the Vjosa showed; where the value is ordinary and the government fixed, discount the figures and think in terms of delay and record.

### Individual Step Success Rates

| Approach                                   | Success Rate  | Timeline     | Cost         | What "Success" Means                            |
|--------------------------------------------|---------------|--------------|--------------|-------------------------------------------------|
| Documentation only                         | 5-10%         | months       | low          | Basis for every other step                      |
| Court challenge to a permit                | 25-50%        | months-years | low-moderate | Permit annulled; delay; precedent               |
| Biodiversity science / value case          | 30-55%        | ongoing      | low          | The basis for protection                        |
| International partnership & campaign       | 35-60%        | ongoing      | low          | Global attention and pressure                   |
| Reframing to permanent protection          | 35-60%        | years        | low          | The whole area saved, not one project           |
| Coalition & public mobilisation            | 30-55%        | ongoing      | low          | The argument won                                |
| Media & international pressure             | 35-60%        | ongoing      | low          | The government and world engaged                |
| Turning the government                     | case-specific | years        | low          | Proponent becomes protector                     |
| All steps combined (high value + partners) | 45-70%        | 2-8 years    | low-moderate | The place permanently protected                 |
| All steps combined (ordinary value)        | 20-45%        | 1-5 years    | low-moderate | Delayed, conditioned, scrutinised; record built |

**Key insight:** every step together beats any single one, and Albania's real strengths are distinctive — **reframing to protection, international and corporate partnership, biodiversity science, court challenges**, and a **persuadable government**. Its constraints are specific: reliance on **partners and a willing government; unfinished implementation**; the saving of **one place** while others are lost; and **weak governance**.

*A note on cost: documenting the value, challenging a permit, and reaching the international campaigns cost little — and international partners often bring resources and expertise. The expenditure that most changes outcomes is not money; it is the patient building of the science, the coalition, and the case for protection — exactly what carried the Vjosa from a dam site to a national park.*

### Effectiveness Visualization

SUCCESS PROBABILITY (protected, stopped, conditioned, or delayed)

HIGH NATURAL VALUE + FLAWED PERMIT + INTERNATIONAL PARTNERS + PERSUADABLE GOVERNMENT:

|                          |        |
|--------------------------|--------|
| All steps combined:      | 45-70% |
| Reframe to protection:   | 35-60% |
| Science + international: | 35-60% |
| Court + media:           | 30-55% |
| Single step:             | 5-60%  |

ORDINARY VALUE / FIXED GOVERNMENT -- no clear case for a park, no strong partners:

|                              |                                       |
|------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| All steps combined:          | 20-45%                                |
| Delay / conditions / record: | more achievable than a permanent save |
| Court challenge alone:       | the strongest single domestic opening |
| Single step:                 | 5-45%                                 |

**How to read this honestly.** The levers that most change outcomes in Albania are **reframing toward permanent protection and the international partnership**, amplified by the science, the courts, and the press. The Vjosa shows the ceiling: a river slated for dams became the first Wild River National Park in Europe. But the limits show the floor: without exceptional value, strong partners, and a persuadable government, the realistic win is delay and a record. Most Albanian fights sit between, and the honest lesson is that the reframing-to-protection lever is real and distinctive — decisive for a place of outstanding value with international backing, far weaker for an ordinary project, where the court challenge and the record must carry the fight. Read the table, then, as a map of where to aim: the exceptional value of the place is the single biggest factor, because it is what unlocks the protection frame, the international standards, and the world's attention. Where the value is genuinely outstanding and can be documented, an Albanian campaign should aim high — at a park — and enlist the international partners who can help win it. Where it is ordinary, the realistic tools are the court challenge and the record, and the honest goal is delay and scrutiny rather than permanent protection.

## Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

1. **Reframing to permanent protection** — Albania's most distinctive lever; turning a defensive fight against one project into a positive campaign for a park saves the whole place, as at the Vjosa.
2. **International and corporate partnership** — the global campaigns, IUCN, and allies like Patagonia that bring attention, expertise, and pressure a local group cannot.
3. **Biodiversity science** — the documented value that justifies the highest protection and anchors the whole case.
4. **Court challenges to permits** — the administrative-court annulments that stop individual projects, buy time, and set precedent, as at the Vjosa.
5. **Turning the government and the record** — the pressure and incentive that convert a proponent into a protector, and the documentation that outlasts a single decision.

## What Albanian Campaigns Actually Show

A few patterns recur. **Reframing wins** — the Vjosa was saved by demanding a park, not just fighting dams. **The science justifies protection** — documented biodiversity built the case. **Courts can annul permits** — a Vjosa dam permit was struck down. **International partners multiply force** — the global campaign and its allies were decisive. **The government can be turned** — proponent became protector. The through-line: **document the natural value; challenge the permits; reach the international campaigns; reframe toward permanent protection; and turn the government** — because in Albania a river slated for dams can become a protected national park.

## STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Every effective campaign begins by finding the exact decision that governs the project — and its weakest point, and, in Albania, the bigger prize beyond it. Vague opposition goes nowhere; opposition to "the cascade of dams that would destroy one of Europe's last wild rivers, home to a thousand species, on flawed permits — which we will answer by demanding the whole river be made a national park" is a case — the case that saved the Vjosa. Answer five questions.

### The Five Core Questions

**1. What is the natural value at stake?** This is the first Albanian question, because a place of **exceptional natural value** — a wild river, an outstanding habitat, rich biodiversity — can justify not just stopping a project but **permanent protection**, the winning frame at the Vjosa. Establish and document that value. The value is the key that unlocks every other Albanian lever — the protection frame, the international partners, the conservation standards, the government's incentive — so establishing it, rigorously and early, is the single most consequential thing an Albanian campaign can do. A place shown to be exceptional can aim at a national park; a place not so shown can, at best, contest a permit.

**2. Is the permit legally vulnerable?** Is the **environmental assessment** deficient, the process flawed? An Albanian **administrative court** can annul such a permit, as it did for a Vjosa dam — a tactical win that buys time and precedent.

**3. Can the fight be reframed toward protection?** Can you demand not merely the stopping of the project but the **permanent protection** of the whole area — a national park or protected area — a positive goal the science justifies and the government might embrace? Ask this question at the very outset, not after years of defensive fighting, because the answer shapes the whole campaign: if permanent protection is achievable, everything — the evidence you gather, the allies you seek, the way you address the government — should be bent toward it from the first week, as the Vjosa's defenders bent their campaign toward a park from their opening press conference.

**4. Can international partners and the government be enlisted?** Can you reach the **international campaigns, IUCN, and allies**, and can the **government be turned** — by pressure, by EU-accession and tourism incentives — from proponent to protector?

**5. Who decides, who benefits, and who is watching?** Which consortium holds the concession, who granted it, who profits; which communities, rivers, and habitats are affected; and which NGOs, scientists, courts, international bodies, press, and public can be engaged. This maps your levers and your audiences at once. Write the answers down and keep them before you, because in a campaign that may run for years and span from a riverside village to an international conservation body, a clear early map of who decides, who profits, who is harmed, and who can help is what keeps the effort aimed and the coalition coordinated through the long fight to protection.

## A Worked Example

Suppose a consortium holds a concession to dam a wild river or develop a place of outstanding value, on a flawed permit, backed by the government.

Working the five questions: the **natural value** — the wild river, the biodiversity — that can justify a park. Is the **permit vulnerable** to a court challenge? Can the fight be **reframed** from stopping the dam to protecting the whole river? Can **international partners** be enlisted and the **government turned**? And the deciders are the government and the consortium, with the courts, IUCN, the international campaigns, the press, and the public as the pressure points.

Within a season you have moved from "we oppose the dam" to a target list: document the river's value; challenge the permit in court; reach the international campaigns; reframe toward a national park; press and persuade the government; and make it a national and international story. That is a campaign, not a complaint — and it draws directly on how the Vjosa was saved. Notice what the exercise did: it converted a diffuse fear into a short list of concrete tasks — document the value, challenge the permit, reach the international campaigns, reframe toward a park, press the government — each tied to a specific lever and each of which can begin now. That is the difference the five questions make, and in Albania the third of them, whether the fight can be reframed toward permanent protection, is the one that most often decides how large the win can be.

## STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

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Documentation is the foundation everything else stands on. A court, the government, IUCN, an international campaign, a journalist, and the public all move on evidence, not indignation — and at the Vjosa the documented value of the river and the flaws in the dam permits were what won. Build your file in three layers.

### Layer 1: The Permit and the Official Record

Get the documents the decision rests on. Obtain the **concession and permit**, the **environmental impact assessment**, and the approvals, and scrutinise the assessment, because a **deficient or flawed assessment** is a ground on which an Albanian court can **annul the permit**, as one was annulled for a Vjosa dam. Obtain the terms of the concession and who holds it. Use what access-to-information exists and the help of the NGOs. The gap between what the paper claims — a sound, beneficial project — and what the natural value and the flawed assessment show is where cases are won.

### Layer 2: The Natural Value

Document the reality the paper understates, and put the **natural value** at the centre, because in Albania it is the foundation of the winning frame — permanent protection. Record the **river, the habitat, the biodiversity** — the species, especially any rare or threatened ones, as the Vjosa surveys found over a thousand species — with the help of



scientists, and, where you can, an organised **biodiversity assessment** that builds the case for the highest protection. Document the **free-flowing river or intact habitat** as a whole system, not just the dam site. Photograph and date it. Record **testimony** from riverside communities and those who know the place. The organised biodiversity assessment deserves particular emphasis, because it was central to the Vjosa: a structured survey, conducted with credible scientists and documented to international standards, produces the kind of evidence — a count of species, a record of threatened ones, an account of an intact ecosystem — that a conservation body and a government can weigh, and that is far harder to dismiss than a general claim that a place is precious. Where a campaign can mount such an assessment, ideally with visible participation from students and the community, it builds both the scientific case and the public engagement at once.

### Layer 3: The Flaws, the Value, and the Case for Protection

Finally, document the defects and the case for a park. Is the **permit's assessment deficient**, a ground for annulment? Does the project **destroy a place of exceptional, documented value**? And — distinctively in Albania — does that value **justify permanent protection**, meeting the **international standards** (such as IUCN's) for a national park or protected area? Assemble the case that the place should not merely be spared this project but protected forever. Each element is a separate ground — for the court challenge, the international campaign, the demand for protection, and the public case — and together they make a case that is hard to wave away. This is the layer that most often decides Albanian fights, because here a project sold as beneficial is revealed to rest on a flawed permit and to threaten a place whose value justifies not just its stopping but its permanent protection — exactly the case that turned the Vjosa from a dam site into a national park. The move from "spare this place from this project" to "protect this place forever" is the whole art of the Albanian campaign, and this layer of documentation is where it is made: by assembling not just the flaws of the permit but the affirmative case that the place meets the international criteria for a park, you hand the government and the conservation bodies everything they need to act, and you change the question before them from whether to stop a dam to whether to create a treasure.

## WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

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This is the practical companion to Step 2: the specific records that decide Albanian cases, and where to obtain them. You will not need every item; you will need the few that expose the flawed permit and establish the value that justifies protection.

### The Permit, the Assessment, and the Paper Trail

- **The concession and permit** — the grant, its holder, its terms, and who signed it.
- **The environmental impact assessment** — its quality and process; a deficient assessment is a ground for annulment, as at the Vjosa.
- **The approvals and the process** — whether the steps and consultations were properly followed.
- **The proponent** — the consortium, its owners and backers, foreign or connected.
- **The protection standards** — the international (IUCN) and national criteria for a national park or protected area, and how your place meets them.

### How to Get Them

Concession and permit records come through the responsible ministries and what access-to-information exists; the assessment through the same and the NGOs; the protection standards through IUCN and the international campaigns. Lean on **allies**: EcoAlbania and the country's environmental NGOs, the international **Save the Blue Heart**-type campaigns, IUCN, and sympathetic scientists and lawyers, who know the permits, the courts, and the road to protection. Move early: challenging the permit before construction, and building the case for protection while the fight is fresh, carry more weight than the same steps taken after the concrete is poured — and court and appeal windows are defined.

### The Ground Evidence

- **The biodiversity and the value** — the species, the habitats, the free-flowing river, from scientists and organised assessments, as the Vjosa surveys documented over a thousand species.
- **The river or habitat as a system** — the whole, not just the project site, to build the case for protecting it all.
- **The harm evidence** — what the project would destroy, dated and photographed.
- **The community and livelihood evidence** — how the river or place sustains riverside communities, from testimony.
- **The protection case** — how the place meets the international standards for a national park.

## Organise It So It Persuades

Keep a **master timeline** of the concession, the permit, the assessment, and the court and campaign steps — the spine of any challenge or protection bid. Keep a **document index** so any fact can be sourced in seconds. And keep an **argument bank** (developed in a later section) that pairs each fact with what it proves, to whom. A well-ordered file is not bureaucracy; it is what lets a resident, a scientist, a lawyer, a journalist, an IUCN expert, an international campaigner, and a minister all see the same clear picture fast, and it guards against the campaign's own worst enemy, a claim that cannot be sourced when the consortium or the ministry pushes back. In a country where a documented case for value can turn a project fight into a permanent protection, the community with the better-kept file — above all the clearest biodiversity science and the strongest case for a park — is very often the one that wins.

## STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION — HOW TO BUILD THE COALITION, LOCAL TO INTERNATIONAL

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Evidence and law do not stop projects on their own. Organised people do — and in Albania, the Vjosa was saved by a coalition that ran from riverside villages to international campaigns. A community's strength here is the breadth of that coalition, and its distinctive reach to the international partners who bring attention, expertise, and pressure a local group cannot.

### Phase 1: The Core and the River

Start with a small, committed core — five to fifteen people who will carry the work — and build the campaign around the **river or place and its value**, because a wild river and its life rouse the public and justify protection. Assign roles: documentation and science liaison, legal, international-campaign liaison, media, community and mayor liaison, and coordination. Agree on the goal — not merely the dam stopped, but the **whole river or place permanently protected** — and on what you will and will not accept. Set the ambitious goal early, even if it seems distant, because it shapes everything that follows: a campaign that decides at the outset to aim for a national park will gather different evidence, seek different allies, and speak to the government in a different register than one that aims only to stop a single dam. The Vjosa's defenders called for a park from their very first press conference, years before they won it, and that early ambition oriented the whole long campaign toward the prize it eventually secured.

### Phase 2: The Local-to-International Coalition

Then widen deliberately, and — distinctively in Albania — **all the way to the international level**, because that reach was decisive at the Vjosa. Bring in the **riverside communities and their mayors**, whose voices root the campaign; the **local environmental NGOs** like EcoAlbania; the **scientists** whose biodiversity work builds the case; the **international campaigns** — Save the Blue Heart, Riverwatch, EuroNatur — and **IUCN**, whose standards and attention move the government; and **allies like Patagonia**, whose backing brings resources and a global platform. Reach the **wider Albanian public**, for whom a wild river is a national treasure, and the **international press**. The Vjosa campaign drew its power from exactly this span — villages, mayors, national NGOs, scientists, international campaigns, IUCN, and a corporate ally as one — which is precisely the spread a winning Albanian campaign needs. Each part supplied something the others could not: the mayors and residents gave the campaign its local legitimacy and its human voice; EcoAlbania gave it a permanent Albanian presence and the capacity to litigate; the scientists gave it the evidence; the international campaigns and IUCN gave it reach and the language of protection; and the corporate ally gave it resources and a global stage. The lesson for any Albanian campaign is that the international ties are not an optional extra but a core part of the machine, because it is largely through them that the pressure and the standards that move the government are brought to bear.

**A worked coalition example.** Facing a dam on a wild river, the riverside communities and mayors form the base; EcoAlbania and the scientists document the river and challenge the permits; the international campaigns and IUCN bring global attention and the standards for a park; a corporate ally amplifies and resources it; and the wider public and international press carry the fight. No single group could have carried it; together they cover the river, the science, the law, the world, and the government — the model that saved the Vjosa.

### Phase 3: Sustaining It

Campaigns die of burnout, not defeat — and an Albanian protection fight is measured in years. Meet on a rhythm. Give people concrete, finishable tasks. Mark small wins — a permit annulled, a biodiversity survey completed, an international



partner won, a wave of coverage, a minister engaged. Rotate the exhausting roles. Keep the coalition broad and its international ties strong, since an Albanian campaign's power is its local-to-international reach, and guard against the split — the promise of jobs or energy — that a proponent will use to divide riverside communities.

## Phase 4: Showing Strength

Numbers and legitimacy must be seen. Turn people out for the biodiversity surveys, the riverbank events, the hearings, and peaceful, well-run demonstrations, as the Vjosa's defenders gathered on the riverbanks. Let the **scientists, the mayors, and respected voices** speak, and bring the **international partners** visibly alongside, so the government and the world see a united campaign backed by global expertise, not a faction. The point is not spectacle; it is to demonstrate — to the government, the courts, IUCN, the press, and the public — that the community and its allies stand united for their river and its permanent protection, as they demonstrated until the park was declared.

## STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES — THE PERMITS, THE COURTS, AND THE PROTECTION

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Albanian law gives communities real tools, and the Vjosa fight used them. You do not need a final ruling to win: challenging a permit, winning an annulment, and pressing the positive case for protection halts a project, buys time, and builds toward the permanent win. Engage lawyers and the NGOs early — but understand the tools yourself.

### The Court Challenge to the Permit

The first lever is the **court challenge**. Albanian **administrative courts** can **annul a concession or permit** for a **deficient environmental assessment** or a flawed process — as a Tirana court did for a Vjosa dam, ruling in favour of the local community and EcoAlbania. A well-built challenge stops the individual project, buys crucial time, creates precedent, and keeps the fight alive while the larger campaign for protection advances. Even where appealed, it holds the line. The Vjosa campaign's court victory is instructive: a Tirana administrative court, ruling in favour of the local community and EcoAlbania, found against a dam on the river, and although the investor and the ministry appealed, the ruling stalled the project and signalled that the permits would not go unchallenged. A court challenge in Albania rarely ends a fight by itself, but it buys the time a protection campaign needs and establishes that the community will contest every step — which itself changes the proponent's and the government's calculations.

### The Case for Permanent Protection

The second lever, and Albania's most distinctive, is the **legal designation of protected status**. The government can declare a **national park or protected area**, giving a place lasting legal protection — as it declared the Vjosa a Wild River National Park. This is the positive prize: not merely defeating one permit, but winning a status that bars the whole category of destruction. Build the case — the documented value, the international standards, the IUCN backing — and press the government to make the designation, the winning frame at the Vjosa. It is worth understanding what the designation actually secured: national-park status to the highest international standard, protecting the free-flowing river and its channel over four hundred kilometres, with a plan to extend protection in a later phase to tributaries and integral areas. That is a categorically stronger outcome than the cancellation of a single dam, because it bars the whole class of destructive projects across the whole river, permanently — which is exactly why the positive campaign for a park, rather than the negative campaign against a dam, is the frame that wins the most in Albania.

### International Standards and Conventions

The third lever is the **international framework**. Albania, an EU-accession candidate, is bound by and sensitive to **international conventions, IUCN standards, and EU environmental expectations**, and a project that breaches them, or a place that meets the criteria for protection, gives you arguments and pressure the government heeds. Invoke these standards, both to challenge a project and to justify a park. Albania's EU-accession ambition gives these standards unusual bite: the country is under sustained pressure to align its environmental law and practice with European norms, and a project that flouts those norms, or a place that plainly merits protection under them, can be pressed both as a legal argument and as a matter of the country's European credentials. A campaign that frames its case in the language of the standards Albania aspires to meet speaks directly to the government's own stated goals.

### The Record and the Precedent

Finally, the **record and the precedent**. Each court challenge, each documented flaw, each international standard invoked builds a record that outlasts a single decision and can win the next round — and a precedent, like the annulment of a dam permit, that strengthens the next challenge.

## Where to Turn and With Whom

Permit challenges go to the **administrative courts**; the case for protection to the **government and the environment ministry**, backed by **IUCN** and the international campaigns; the standards through the **international bodies**. Get help early: EcoAlbania and Albania's environmental lawyers and NGOs, the international campaigns, and IUCN know the permits, the courts, the standards, and the road to protection. Help engaged while the permit is fresh and before construction is worth far more than help sought after — and in Albania, the strongest strategy marries the **court challenge** to the individual permit with the **positive campaign** for permanent protection.

## TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

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You have a file of evidence. Now you must turn it into arguments — because the same fact persuades a court, the government, IUCN, a journalist, and the public in different ways. Learning to translate your evidence for each audience is what lets a community reach every lever at once.

### One Fact, Many Arguments

Take a single documented fact — say, that a cascade of dams would destroy one of Europe's last wild rivers, home to over a thousand species, on permits with deficient assessments. That one fact becomes:

- **A court argument:** the permit's environmental assessment is deficient and the concession should be annulled — the win at the Vjosa.
- **A protection argument (to the government):** this river's exceptional value justifies, and demands, permanent protection as a national park — the winning frame.
- **An international argument:** one of Europe's last wild rivers, meeting IUCN's standards, is at risk — the case that brings global attention and expertise.
- **A public argument:** they would dam our wild river and destroy a thousand species — the case that rouses the nation.
- **A value argument (the science):** the documented biodiversity meets the criteria for the highest protection — the anchor of the whole campaign.

Same fact, five arguments, five audiences. Go through your strongest facts and, for each, ask what it proves to each audience. That table is your campaign's argument bank — and in Albania the arguments that most often decide things are the **protection** one, because it wins the whole river, and the **value-and-international** one, because it brings the pressure and the standards. Keep the arguments anchored to the same documented facts, so a claim made to a reporter can be backed in the science and a claim made to the government can be proven by the surveys; consistency across audiences is itself persuasive.

### Match the Argument to the Audience

**The courts** want the deficiency framed precisely against the law — the flawed assessment, the improper process — with the documents that prove it.

**The government** responds to the case for protection framed in its own interest — the prestige of a first-in-Europe park, the tourism, the EU-accession credit, the international goodwill — alongside the value and the pressure. This is the key to turning a government that began as the proponent: it must be shown that protection serves its own interests better than the dam does. For Albania, an EU-accession candidate eager for international standing and for tourism, the chance to declare the first wild river national park in Europe — celebrated by global conservation bodies and a famous company, drawing visitors and goodwill — was an offer worth more than a single hydropower plant. A campaign that frames protection as the government's own opportunity, not merely a demand upon it, gives the government a way to say yes.

**IUCN and the international bodies** respond to the documented value measured against their protection standards.

**Journalists** need a specific, verified, vivid story with a hook: a named wild river, its species, a cascade of dams, and the David-and-Goliath of communities and scientists against the consortium.

**The public** needs the argument simple and true: they would destroy our wild river, and we can make it a park forever.

**The coalition itself** needs to see the fight is winnable and the goal worth it, so it holds together through the years to protection.

## STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY — HOW PRESS COVERAGE SHIFTS OUTCOMES

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Media is not vanity; it is a lever. Coverage raises the cost of a project, reaches the government and the international community, and builds the public will that makes protection possible. The Vjosa was, in the end, won partly in the world's eye: the coverage of one of Europe's last wild rivers threatened by dams made it an international cause and made its protection a prize the government wanted to claim.

### Build the Story

Reporters and the public need specifics: a named place and stake, a documented threat, and a positive goal. "A project threatens the environment" is not a story; "a cascade of dams would destroy one of Europe's last wild rivers, home to over a thousand species — and it could instead become Europe's first wild river national park" is. Lead with your strongest verified facts — the wild river, the biodiversity, the threat — and the hopeful frame of protection, and offer a human and scientific voice: a mayor, a resident, a scientist. In Albania the story of a wild river that could be saved forever is uniquely powerful.

### Reach the Right Outlets

Work outward in rings. **Local and community voices** first — the riverside towns. Then the **national outlets** — Albania's press and broadcasters. Then, crucially, the **international ring** — the global press, the conservation and river networks, IUCN, and allies like Patagonia — which brings the world's attention and the standards that move the government, and makes protection an international prize, as at the Vjosa. Feed each ring what it needs, and let coverage in one pull in the next. The **international ring is especially decisive** in Albania, because the government heeds its international standing and the world's conservation attention. A story that a country is about to destroy one of Europe's last wild rivers travels far, and a story that it could instead create the continent's first wild river national park travels further still, because it offers the world's media something rare — a hopeful environmental outcome. The Vjosa's international coverage did double work: it shamed the dam plans and it celebrated the protection prize, so that the government came to see the park not as a defeat forced upon it but as an achievement the world would applaud.

### Sustain It, and Keep It True

A single article changes little; a drumbeat changes decisions. Plan a sequence — the biodiversity, the flawed permits, the court wins, the case for a park, the international backing — so there is always a next hook, and build your own clear record so the story reaches the world and endures. Keep messaging disciplined, accurate, and consistent, and keep the positive frame — not just against the dams, but for the park; one exaggeration handed to the consortium can cost credibility with the courts, IUCN, and the government. Verified, specific, value-and-protection-centred, and relentless — that is the coverage that shifts outcomes here, and that helped turn a nation, the world, and a government toward saving the Vjosa. Keep the hopeful frame to the fore, because it is the campaign's greatest asset with the press and the public alike: a story of a river that can still be saved, and made a national park, invites people to be part of a victory, where a story only of loss invites resignation. The Vjosa campaign consistently offered its audiences a win to be won, and that framing helped carry it through the years to the day the park was declared.

## EMAILS & LETTERS

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Written communications are how you object, demand, create a record, and reach the bodies that can act — the courts, the government, IUCN, and the international campaigns. Each does double duty: it asks for something and it documents that you asked. Keep copies of everything, and send important items so that receipt is provable. Below are adaptable templates for the situations you will meet most often. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in the value, the flawed permit, and the case for protection.

### 8A. Court Challenge to a Permit (via Counsel)

**To:** the administrative court (through your lawyer) **Subject:** Challenge to concession/permit [reference] for [project]

We, the community of [place] and [NGO], challenge concession/permit [reference] for [project] on [river/place]. The environmental impact assessment is **deficient** — [the missing survey, the ignored value, the flawed process] — and the concession should be **annulled**, as a Vjosa dam permit was annulled in favour of the local community and EcoAlbania. We attach the assessment and our evidence of the place's value.

## 8B. Demand to the Government for Protection

**To:** the Prime Minister / the Minister of Tourism and Environment **Subject:** Protect [river/place] as a national park

We, the communities of [place] and [coalition], call on you to protect [river/place] as a **national park**. Its exceptional value — [the free-flowing river, the biodiversity, the thousand species] — meets the international standards for the highest protection, as the Vjosa did before it became Europe's first Wild River National Park. We ask you to make [place] a permanent protected area, to the benefit of Albania's nature, tourism, and standing. We attach our scientific case.

## 8C. Letter to IUCN / an International Body

**To:** IUCN / the international conservation body **Subject:** [River/place] in Albania — a candidate for protection

We are the communities and NGOs defending [river/place], one of [Europe's last wild rivers / an outstanding habitat], threatened by [project]. We attach our biodiversity evidence and ask for your assessment against your protection standards and your support for its designation as a national park, as with the Vjosa. Your standards and attention would greatly strengthen the case.

## 8D. Instructing a Lawyer / NGO

**To:** an environmental lawyer / EcoAlbania-type NGO / the international campaign **Subject:** [Project] on [river/place] — permit, protection, and the law

We believe [project] is unlawful and destructive because [the permit's assessment is deficient / it would destroy a place of exceptional value]. We attach the permit, the assessment, and our biodiversity evidence, and seek advice on **challenging the permit in court**, building the **case for a national park**, engaging **IUCN and the international campaigns**, and reaching the government. Please advise on the strongest ground and the deadlines.

## 8E. Letter to the Consortium / Investor

**To:** [the dam/development consortium / investor] **Subject:** [Project] — legal, reputational, and value risk

We write regarding your [concession for / investment in] [project] on [river/place]. The project [one-line stake — e.g. "would destroy one of Europe's last wild rivers, home to over a thousand species"], rests on a deficient permit, and faces [a court challenge / a national and international campaign / a bid for permanent protection]. We remind you that a Vjosa dam permit was annulled and the river made a national park. We ask you to weigh the legal, reputational, and value risk, and we are glad to share our evidence.

## 8F. Letter to the International Campaign / Corporate Ally

**To:** [Save the Blue Heart / Riverwatch / EuroNatur / a values-driven company] **Subject:** [River/place] in Albania — please help us save it

We are defending [river/place], threatened by [project], and we aim not just to stop it but to win **permanent protection** as a national park. We ask for your partnership — your attention, your expertise, your platform, your resources — as the Vjosa campaign had. We attach our evidence and can connect you with mayors, residents, and scientists.

## 8G. Email to a Reporter (National or International)

**To:** [journalist] **Subject:** Story tip: [specific finding] — [the river / the park]

I follow your coverage of [beat]. We have something your readers should know, with a clear hook: [documents and biodiversity evidence] show [quantified finding — e.g. "a cascade of dams would destroy one of Europe's last wild rivers, home to over a thousand species — which could instead become a national park"]. It echoes how the Vjosa was saved. I can share the full file and connect you with a mayor and a scientist. Could we talk this week?

## 8H. Petition / Public Statement

**To:** the government and the public **Subject:** Save [river/place] — make it a national park

We call on the people of Albania and the government to save [river/place] from [project], and to protect it forever as a **national park**. It is [one-line value], and it can be a treasure for Albania and a first for the world, as the Vjosa became Europe's first Wild River National Park. Sign, share, and stand with us.

## Using the Templates Well

Send important communications so that receipt is provable, and log every one in your timeline — the record of a court challenge, a demand for protection, or a letter to IUCN is itself evidence, and exactly what the courts, the government, and the international bodies will heed. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in the value, the flawed permit, and the case for protection; attach your evidence; and route them, where you can, through the coalition, EcoAlbania and the NGOs, the international campaigns, IUCN, your lawyers, and the press. The reply, or the decision, becomes part of your record, and in Albania that record feeds the levers that matter most: the court challenge, the case for permanent protection, the international partnership, and the government won over.

## IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

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Not everyone can run a long campaign. With a few hours a week you can still do real damage to a bad project — and start the road to protection. In rough order of impact for the effort:

- 1. Document the natural value.** In Albania, the documented value of a river or place is the foundation of the winning frame — protection. Record the biodiversity and the value, with scientists if you can (Step 2).
- 2. Challenge the permit.** If the assessment is deficient, an administrative court can annul the permit (8A) — a tactical win that buys time and precedent, as at the Vjosa.
- 3. Reframe toward a park.** Do not just fight the dam; demand the whole river or place be made a **national park** (8B, 8H). This is the move that wins in Albania.
- 4. Reach the international campaigns and IUCN.** The Save the Blue Heart-type campaigns, IUCN, and allies (8C, 8F) bring attention, expertise, and pressure a local group cannot.
- 5. Press the government.** Make the case for protection in the government's own interest — prestige, tourism, EU accession (8B).
- 6. Build the coalition.** Riverside communities, mayors, NGOs, scientists (8D).
- 7. Reach the press.** A vivid wild-river-and-park story (8G) carries the fight to the world.

Do only the first three and you will have documented the value, challenged the permit, and reframed toward a park — the exact foundation on which the Vjosa was saved. Then come back and read the rest. Even the shortest version has a spine: document the value, challenge the permit, reframe toward a national park. Those three moves are exactly the ones that, done early, put the decisive Albanian levers into play — the documented value that unlocks the protection frame, the court challenge that buys time and precedent, and the ambitious demand for a park that turns a defensive fight into a winnable one — and they are within reach of a handful of determined riverside residents with a clear case and the will to aim high.

## WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

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Albania's system is tilted in specific ways you must understand, so you neither waste effort nor miss the levers that work.

### Where the Tilt Shows

The tilt here is real. **Governance is weak** and institutions corruptible, so concessions can be granted to connected or foreign consortia on thin assessments, and enforcement is uneven. The government has **pushed hydropower and development** hard, treating rivers as sites for dams. **Court processes are slow**, and wins can be appealed and delayed. And even a protected area can face **development pressure** — roads, an airport near a delta, tourism — beside or within it. Where these tilts bite, a lever misapplied gives little. But the Vjosa shows that the right combination — the value, the courts, the international partners, and the reframing to protection — can overcome even a government that began as the

proponent.

## What Still Works — And Some Is Distinctive

The decisive point is that even where the system tilts, real and distinctive levers remain.

**The courts can still annul a permit.** A deficient assessment is a ground an administrative court can act on, as it did for a Vjosa dam.

**The value still justifies protection.** Documented exceptional value builds a case for a national park that the science and the international standards support.

**The international partners still bring pressure.** IUCN, the global campaigns, and allies reach a government sensitive to its standing.

**The government can still be turned.** The incentives of prestige, tourism, and EU accession can convert a proponent into a protector.

This is the most distinctive and hopeful feature of the Albanian landscape: unlike a captured state that must simply be fought, or a wealthy one indifferent to outside pressure, Albania's government is both movable and hungry for international standing, which means a well-run campaign can offer it a face-saving, even flattering, path to reversing course. The art is to make protection the government's idea and its triumph, so that granting the park becomes not a concession wrung from it but an achievement it wishes to claim.

**The record still endures.** What you document and the precedent you set outlast a single decision and can win the next round.

## The Honest Frame

So the honest frame for Albania is, on the strength of the Vjosa, genuinely hopeful — with the cautions named. The reframing to protection, the international partnership, the science, and the courts give a community real and distinctive power, and the Vjosa proves a river slated for dams can become a national park. But the reliance on partners and a willing government, the unfinished implementation, the other rivers still lost, and the weak governance are real. So diagnose your fight honestly: document the **value**; challenge the **permit**; reach the **international campaigns and IUCN**; reframe toward **permanent protection**; and turn the **government** — and where a park is out of reach, pursue the annulment, the delay, and the record that are the realistic gains. Matched to the fight, these are among the stronger community tools in the region.

## WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO IS CAPTURED

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Albania has real problems with corruption and with the closeness between the state and connected or foreign consortia, so this section matters. When a project advances not on its merits but through such influence — a concession granted on a thin assessment to a connected consortium, a dam pushed despite the harm — your strategy shifts toward exposing it and going around it.

### How to Tell

Look for the signatures of capture. A **concession granted quietly** to a connected or foreign consortium on a **thin or flawed assessment**; a project **pushed despite** documented harm and opposition; **favourable terms** that serve the few; and **assessments skipped or rushed**. Trace the concession and the money: who holds it, who granted it, who profits. In Albania, a destructive project on a valuable river or place is often a matter of connected interests and a government that treats nature as a resource to be conceded, rather than an honest weighing of value.

### Who Can Be Captured — and Who Is Harder

Be clear-eyed about where influence reaches. **Parts of the government, the ministries, and the concession process** can be captured or connected. But some forces are far harder to capture, and they are your targets: the **administrative courts**, which have ruled against dam permits; **IUCN and the international bodies**, beyond national politics; the **international campaigns and press**; the **independent scientists**; and the **public and the riverside**



**communities.** Capture thrives in the concession process; your task is to lift the matter into the light — into the courts, the international standards, the world's attention, and the case for protection.

## What to Do

Do not rely on a captured process. Instead, **document the concession and its flaws precisely** — who granted it, who holds it, who profits, and how the assessment fell short — and take it, with the value at stake, to the forces beyond the capture: the **courts**; **IUCN and the international campaigns**; the **press**; and the **public**. Pair the exposure with the positive case for **protection**, so the impropriety and the value surface together. In Albania, exposing how connected interests would sacrifice a place of exceptional value strips a project's legitimacy and strengthens the case for a park — as the Vjosa campaign turned a conceded dam site into Europe's first Wild River National Park. There is a strategic point here specific to Albania: because the government values its international image, exposing a concession as a corrupt or connected deal does more than embarrass officials at home — it threatens the very standing the government is trying to build, and so raises the cost of persisting with the project relative to the reward of protecting the place. Exposure and the positive case for a park thus work together, the one raising the cost of the dam and the other lowering the cost of the alternative.

## INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

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The five steps win when they run together. Here is how they fit across the life of a fight — which in Albania turns on the value, the courts, the international partners, and the reframing to protection.

### Early (Months 0-12): Value, Permit, and the Frame

Pin down the project and its permit (Step 1), and document the **natural value** — the river, the biodiversity — that is the foundation of the winning frame (Step 2). Build the **core and the coalition**, local to international (Step 3). Move at once on what is decisive: **challenge the permit** in court (8A); **reach the international campaigns and IUCN** (8C, 8F); and begin to **reframe toward a national park** (8B, 8H). Begin the **biodiversity science** (Step 2). Reach **EcoAlbania-type NGOs and a lawyer** early (8D). This phase lays the foundation, and in Albania the science, the court challenge, and the frame begun here are what ultimately win.

### Middle (Years 1-5): Escalate Toward Protection

Broaden the coalition and its international ties (Step 3). Turn your evidence into arguments for each audience (Turning Evidence). Escalate as the facts warrant — the **permit annulled**, the **case for protection** pressed on the government, the **international backing** built, the **IUCN standards** invoked (Step 4). Reach the **consortium and investors** (8E). Build the media drumbeat from local to national to international (Step 5). Each front feeds the others. Do the time-critical things first — the permit challenge within its window — because those chances do not return. And sequence the campaign so that the pieces reinforce one another toward the prize: the biodiversity surveys feeding the case for a park, the court challenges buying the time to build that case, the international coverage and IUCN engagement raising the reward for the government, and the corporate and campaign partnerships arriving with resources at the moments they matter most. The Vjosa took the better part of a decade, and its defenders won by keeping every front advancing toward the single goal of permanent protection.

### Later (Years 2-8+): The Protection, and Guarding It

Win the prize — the **permanent protection**, the national park — and then guard it, because in Albania implementation is unfinished: press for the **extension of protection** to tributaries and integral areas, for **strong boundaries and management**, and against **development pressure** beside the protected place. The Vjosa itself illustrates why this vigilance matters: the designation came in phases, with the free-flowing tributaries and the delta to be added later, and a protected river can still be pressed by roads, tourism, and other development at its edges. Winning the park is a milestone, not the end; a community that disbands at the declaration may find the protection hollowed out, while one that stays organised can hold the government to the full promise and defend the boundaries against the next incursion. And, against a fight where a park is out of reach, pursue the **annulment, the delay, and the record** that are the realistic gains. Judge success honestly. Sometimes it is a river made a national park, as at the Vjosa. Sometimes it is a permit annulled and a project delayed while the coalition holds. Both are victories worth the fight.

## The Shape of a Campaign

## FINAL ASSESSMENT

Albania gives communities a genuinely powerful — and distinctive — set of tools, and the honest measure of this guide is how squarely it faces both their strength and their limits.

The strengths are real and distinctive. **Reframing the fight toward permanent protection** — a national park — turns a defensive battle against one project into a positive campaign that saves the whole place, as it saved the Vjosa.

**International and corporate partnership** brings attention, expertise, and pressure a local group cannot. **Biodiversity science** builds the case for the highest protection. **Court challenges** can annul individual permits. And a **persuadable government**, seeking prestige, tourism, and EU accession, can be turned from proponent to protector. These are the levers that let the defenders of the Vjosa make a river slated for dams into the first Wild River National Park in Europe.

The limits are just as real, and this guide names them. The win leaned on **international partners and a willing government** not every fight will have. **Implementation is unfinished**, protection can be partial, and it **saved one river** while others were dammed. And **weak governance, corruption, and development pressure** persist. No guide should pretend these away; in Albania, the art is to reframe toward protection and to marshal the science, the courts, and the world.

So the realistic promise is this: **document the value; challenge the permit; reach the international campaigns and IUCN; reframe toward permanent protection; and turn the government — running all of it together.** Do that, and against a project threatening a place of exceptional value, with strong partners and a persuadable government, you can win not just its stopping but its permanent protection, as the Vjosa was protected; against an ordinary project, you can annul the permit, delay it, and build the record while the coalition holds. Do it as the defenders of the Vjosa did — a coalition from riverside villages to international campaigns that documented a river's life, struck down its dam permits, and turned a government into the protector of the first wild river national park in Europe.

A last word on ambition and the winning frame. Albania's lesson is that the strongest response to a destructive project can be not merely to stop it but to demand something permanent and positive in its place — protection — and that a community armed with the science, the courts, and the world can turn even a government that wanted the dam into the guardian of a park. The proponent counts on a defensive fight, one dam at a time, and on your fatigue. Its advantage is the concession and the state's habit of treating nature as a resource. That habit is real and deeply rooted, the legacy of a period in which Albania threw itself into hydropower and treated its rivers as a resource to be exploited, and it will not vanish because one river was saved. But habits can be broken by a striking enough counter-example, and the Vjosa is now exactly that — a demonstration, celebrated at home and abroad, that a wild river is worth more protected than dammed, which every future Albanian campaign can invoke. Yours is a river whose value the world recognises, courts that can annul a flawed permit, international partners who bring pressure and expertise, and the proven fact that a wild river slated for destruction became Europe's first wild river national park. Play to that. Keep the science and the record, keep the river's value and the case for protection at the centre, keep the coalition broad and international, challenge the permits, press for the park, and treat every court filing, every survey, every international ally, and every demand for protection as a brick in a wall no consortium can climb.

The tools are here, and Albania itself proved them: a coalition of communities, scientists, and international campaigns turned a river slated for a cascade of dams into the first Wild River National Park in Europe. What decides the outcome, in the end, is method, ambition, and a public that treasures its river enough to demand not that it be spared this one dam, but that it be protected forever — and those you supply, along with the proof, in the Vjosa, that the demand can be won. Begin today, begin with the river's value and the affirmative case for a park — the science, the species, the free-flowing whole — and build from there. Communities before you have turned what looked like a lost river into a protected treasure — dam permits struck down in court, a wild river saved forever as a national park, a first of its kind for a whole continent. What was won at the Vjosa can be won again. So can yours. A wild river that a whole programme of dams had marked for destruction is now, instead, protected forever as the first of its kind on the continent, won by ordinary people who refused to fight only defensively and dared to demand something permanent — and that example, and the method behind it, are now clearly and fully yours to use.